

The 'R' Word

THE PANDEMIC ISN'T EVEN OVER BUT ONE OF ITS DREADED AFTER-EFFECTS SEEMS TO HAVE BEGUN IN EARNEST. From record-breaking wholesale inflation to consumer spending slowing down, the 'R' word is out in the open. Financial analysts aren't whispering about the recession anymore, they're busy preparing for it. And so should you, as we all should, to be honest.

I remember the last recession, the Great Recession of 2008 as history refers to it now. I'd just turned 22, completely oblivious to the pandemonium unfolding in the US and world's financial markets, and was busy doing my own thing — earning my stripes in this profession. Without the slightest idea of the global economic meltdown taking place behind-the-scenes, I even got a pay raise after getting confirmed within three months, believe it or not. In that moment, I felt like Leonardo DiCaprio's character from Titanic — king of the world!

Living alone in a new city with no parental oversight, I did what any self-respecting young adult with no worries and the best job in the world would do: I started splurging. Manchester United jerseys got delivered from Old Trafford to my humble shared room in Bengaluru, bought my first laptop completely online because offline was uncool, 'invested' in way too many .com domain names than was good for me, upgraded my gaming peripherals for no apparent reason, ate at restaurants and shopped at expensive malls way too often. While I was doing all of this, I did save money — come on, I wasn't that stupid. But the excesses I enjoyed that year were definitely a cut above my conservative middle-class upbringing, and I did it just because I could. I was young, life was good, what could possibly go wrong, right?

Less than a year later in 2009, I was staring at a 15% pay cut despite excelling in everything I could at work. Somewhere between feeling dumbstruck and gobsmacked, I was staring at my own recession-fuelled misfortune. Not just my ex-employer, but most people I ran into in everyday life were harping on the same tune: companies were cutting costs willy-nilly, austerity measures were in force, and all non-

essential spending was suspended. All normal and logical steps, now that I think about it, but my younger self found it hard to compute.

Thanking every god I could remember for not throwing me in the unemployment line, I went from glass half empty to glass half full — actually, more like a quarter but nevermind.

Not only did I learn to stretch every single rupee, I also started caring for my belongings extra hard — my laptop, my earphones, my phone, external hard drive and other electronics I had purchased with my own money. They were my prized possessions I couldn't afford to live without, I would be incomplete without them. I stopped using my laptop while eating food at home, for fear of accidentally spilling a drink on it and ruining it altogether. I had almost developed an OCD of cleaning my earphones of sweat, grime or wax far too often than my own ear, I vividly remember. Not one to sweep my room every single day, I declared war on dust by never opening the window (meant for fresh air) to protect all my gadgets and gear from the bane of all electronics — until my room started smelling musty and I reversed course. Basically, I was prepared to do whatever extra needed to be done to ensure my tech devices had long, successful lives.

Looking back now, I feel lucky to have been spared the worst of what the Great Recession did to a lot of people back then. I reflect upon 2008-2009 as essential character building years of my life, shaping me in ways that have left an indelible mark on how I think and function even to this day. As a new recession looms, I don't have much in terms of advice. Remember to save money to spare yourself extra stress. Stretch that phone, laptop, TV, or any other electronic gadget you're thinking of upgrading for a little more time. And while you're at it, don't forget to open your room for some fresh air every now and then. **d**



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